and musicians who use traditional instruments like the Nagara, Murli, Janjhra, Nagfani, Bhorrindo, and Damru. The songs could be heard even in our tents.

The visit to the White Rann was the highlight of the stay. If I had chosen to see the sunrise, Tent City staffers would have become alarm clocks at 5:45 am to inform me that morning tea was available. At sunrise and sunset, visitors descend on the White Desert, carrying their phone cameras and smiles. The crowd is heavier at sunset—it's harder to wake up after a night of culture—with some keen to slip on traditional Kutch skirts and tops designed with bright threads and mirrorwork and pose for photos with the sun.

That evening, our ride to the White Rann was bumpy. A grumpy camel with black tattoos dragged our open cart with us seated on it to the spot where the white desert was prettiest. Some camels ambled along, while others, like our Sanjay, decided to gallop rather fast towards the destination. We sunk our feet into thin layers of salt-caked-over blackish soil as we walked toward the perfect spot to capture the sun. The faint music of Kutchi songs came in fits and spurts from spots where vendors had set up shop. But not even gorgeous textiles could distract from the setting sun's changing colours, making it hard to look away. The sun's rays, from a thin line at the horizon to the bright orange of sunset, took over my photo gallery.

The next day, the drive to Nirona Village, an hour-and-half from the Tent City, cut through the Banni grasslands, an arid landscape, where buffaloes slowly chewed on grass, and women carried milk containers on their covered heads. The sight conjured up words from Keki Daruwalla's short story 'Love Across the Salt Desert,' which I read in high school. Our guide, Iqbal, told us that every year, the buffaloes of the Banni grasslands compete over which can offer the largest quantity of milk. Some champions had managed 20-23 litres per day.

At Nirona village, we navigated the narrow lanes to reach Padma Shri Abdul Gafur Khatri's home, filled with the 400-year-old art form of Rogan paintings. The paint is made by boiling castor oil for two days and adding vegetable pigments and binding agents. A 'kalam,' a sleek metal instrument, is used to create incredible designs on cloth, making the art a gift for visiting dignitaries. In 2014, Prime Minister Narendra Modi gifted President Barack Obama a Rogan painting, a photo of which was hung on



FIT FOR A DESERT QUEEN
The opulent Rajwadi suite at the White Rann Tent City

THE INFORMATION

GETTING THERE:
From the Sardar Vallabhai Patel Airport in Ahmedabad, Star Air takes 1hr 10min to fly to Bhuj. The White Rann tent city is 80 kilometres from Bhuj airport. Alternatively, the Kutch SF Express takes 6hr 45min to travel from Ahmedabad Junction to Bhuj.

THE STAY:
At the White Rann Tent City, rate range from Rs 14,000 to Rs 55,000 on double occupancy per night. The rate is inclusive of all meals and experiences and excludes taxes. The rate differs based on whether it's a full-moon night and will be different for the Christmas period.

Accommodation options range from the Darbari Suite at the top end (which offers a king-sized bed, living room, two bedrooms, private dining area, and ensuite toilet) to the Rajwadi Suite (living room, bedroom, dressing room, ensuite toilet), the Super Premium Tents (double bed, front porch, attached bathroom), Premium Tents, Deluxe AC Swiss Cottages, and Non AC Swiss Cottages. The tent city also has its guide for visits to Nirona village and the UNESCO Heritage Site of Dholavira.

At the Evoke Dholavira resort, the minimum tariff starts at Rs 8,500 for double occupancy per night and includes breakfast, excluding taxes.

Rann Utsav: www.rannutsav.com | Evoke Dholavira: www.evokedholavira.com